

poor Gängeviertel district of Hamburg,
close to the docks. It was destroyed by
Allied bombs in World War II.

Youthful talent

Johannes Brahms was born in Hamburg in northern Germany, the country's largest port city. His father was a jobbing musician who played several string and wind instruments, and his mother (aged 44 at his birth, 17 years older than her husband) was a seamstress. The traditional view is that the family were wretchedly poor, living in a slum, but this is an exaggeration. Although their finances were often precarious, the family were respectable and happy, and Brahms was devoted to his parents and siblings (an elder sister and a younger brother). He was educated at good schools and his outstanding talent at the piano was nurtured by skillful and caring teachers.

Brahms first performed in public when he was ten. By his early teens, he was helping supplement the family income by playing the piano in restaurants and theaters, giving lessons to local children, and making arrangements for brass bands. According to some accounts, he also played in sleazy dockside taverns that were little better than brothels, and this experience is said to have scarred him for life, souring his relationships with women. However, many scholars now dismiss this as myth.